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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 231: Rudiments of Directing - Text, Space and the Six Visual Tools

Directing as preparation, composition and communication

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 200L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Why this pack exists

Directing is not shouting instructions from the back of the hall. This pack covers script analysis for directors, the six visual tools named in the department's course description, blocking and composition, rehearsal technique and the director's production paperwork.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Analyse a script for given circumstances, spine and directorial concept.
- Apply the six visual tools: ground plan, composition, picturisation, movement, rhythm and pantomimic dramatisation.
- Block a scene for clarity and emphasis.
- Run a rehearsal with a clear plan and give usable notes.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Script analysis for directors

You cannot stage what you have not understood.

- Given circumstances: time, place, society, relationships and prior events.
- Spine: the through-line of action that holds the production together.
- Units and beats: divide the scene into playable sections.
- Character objectives and obstacles, scene by scene.
- Theme: the argument the production will make visible.

- Design requirements implied by the text.

The six visual tools

These are the department's named tools; know them by name and use.

- Ground plan: the spatial arrangement of set, entrances and furniture.
- Composition: where bodies sit in the frame of the stage or camera.
- Picturisation: composing stage pictures that tell the story.
- Movement: planned and motivated physical action across the space.
- Rhythm: pace, pause and tempo changes that shape tension.
- Pantomimic dramatisation: telling story through physical action without words.

> **Directing is choosing**
> A production without choices becomes a reading. Decide what the audience should notice in each beat, then use the tools to make them notice it.

Rehearsal and notes

Rehearsal technique is a professional skill in its own right.

- Plan each rehearsal with a goal, a sequence and a stopping point.
- Start with table work before blocking if the text is dense.
- Give notes that are specific, playable and few.
- Never give a note that contradicts the actor's objective without explanation.
- Rehearse transitions, entrances and exits as rigorously as dialogue.
- Keep a prompt script with blocking and cues.

OUTLINE ARCHIVE

Session record: THA 231

2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Year demarcation matters: a course code that existed in 2018 may have been renumbered, merged or dropped by 2019, and the department now also runs a film track. Read the year label before you rely on a code. The current entry below is a compiled map - take it to your course rep or the departmental office and confirm it before registration.

2018 — Archived course description — ARCHIVED

- The 2018 page describes the director and the six visual tools: ground plan, composition, picturisation, movement, rhythm and pantomimic dramatisation
- Play analysis and communication of meaning to varied audiences
- Emphasis on proscenium dominance, model making and performance space configuration

Source: unizik.edu.ng - Theatre & Film Studies course description (page dated 31 May 2018; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2019 — Archived programme listing — ARCHIVED

- THA 231 Rudiments of Directing, 3 credits, first semester, 200 level
- THA 322 Script Analysis and Interpretation for Performance follows at 300 level
- THA 433 Studies in Technical Directing appears at 400 level

What changed: The 2019 listing gives directing a three-step ladder (231, 322, 433) rather than a single described course.

Source: arts.unizik.edu.ng - Theatre Arts programme and course map (page dated 18 Oct 2019; original URL now returns 404) (retrieved 2026-10-22)

2025/2026 — Compiled working map — CURRENT WORKING MAP

- Rudiments of directing remains the 200-level directing core
- The six visual tools are still the named framework to use in answers
- Confirm whether your directing assessment includes a staged scene or a written prompt book

Source: Compiled by ZikShare from the archived 2018 and 2019 departmental pages plus the published stress areas; this is a working map, not an official handout (retrieved 2026-10-22)

Archive means: this records what a public departmental page listed in that year. It is not a guarantee of the current curriculum, and ZikShare is not affiliated with UNIZIK.

PRACTICE, NOT PREDICTION

Check your understanding

These questions are written for this pack to test the ideas above. They are not past examination questions and do not predict what your lecturer will set. Answer first, then compare.

1. Name the six visual tools of directing.

Answer: Ground plan, composition, picturisation, movement, rhythm and pantomimic dramatisation.

2. What are given circumstances?

Answer: The established conditions of the play - time, place, society, relationships and prior events - that shape character action.

3. Why must notes be playable?

Answer: An actor can act an action such as 'make him leave' but cannot act an abstraction such as 'be more intense'.

4. How does rhythm affect a scene?

Answer: Variation in pace, pause and tempo controls tension, emphasis and the audience's attention.

5. What belongs in a prompt script?

Answer: Blocking, cue calls, scene changes and notes for technical departments.

Your 7-step action plan

Tick each step only when you have done it. A tick you cannot defend is worse than an empty box.

- [ ] Analyse a short scene into units and beats.
- [ ] Write a one-page directorial concept.
- [ ] Draw a ground plan for your scene.
- [ ] Block two pages and rehearse them with actors.
- [ ] Practise giving three playable notes.
- [ ] Time a run-through and adjust the rhythm.
- [ ] Review a recorded scene and identify two composition errors.

Keep going

One pack will not carry a semester. Pair this with your lecture notes, tutorials, and the past questions your department actually releases. If a topic still feels unclear, take a specific question to your lecturer or course rep - "I do not understand the difference between X and Y" gets a better answer than "I do not understand this course".

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YOUR WORKSPACE

Notes, questions and things to ask

Use this page in class or during revision. Write questions you could not answer instead of copying slides.

Three ideas I can now explain without notes:

A question I still cannot answer:

For my lecturer or course rep:

Next revision action and date: